

CALL FOR JUSTICE Ketan's father Vishal Agarwal (in white shirt) leads a candlelight vigil in Pune for his dead son, June 27

allegedly following close behind. The police say Siya sat on the ground, a signal for Chetan to rush in and push Ketan. In the event, both of them reportedly pushed the victim to his death. The police traced Chetan's mobile number, but found that his mobile data was off from 7 am to 5:40 pm on June 18. The phone was only used to receive calls. "We asked callers about who had answered the calls. They said it was the worker in his shop," says a police officer. SP Gill believes Chetan swapped the phones with a worker in their shop to create an alibi for himself.

The police version of the sequence of events goes like this: Chetan rides his two-wheeler to the fort, climbs to the summit with the hoodie on to avoid being identified by Ketan, pushes or helps push the victim down the cliff, returns to the base, and leaves. According to this version, he completed the trek up and down the fort in just 48 minutes. Investigators estimate he spent 8-10 minutes at the summit, a window they believe was sufficient to execute the murder. Chetan's lawyer Ram Shahane, though, is unconvinced. "My client has been falsely implicated in the case. The account about the hoodie and the mobile phone was cooked up by the police, and is not proven by concrete evidence," says Shahane.



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PRAVIN GOYAL
Accused Siya Goyal's father

FAMILY CONCERNS

Ketan's father Vishal, too, has in retrospect made a number of allegations in his statement to the police. This includes his late son's fears that Siya was having an affair after their first trip to Lohagad, and her constant references to 'friend Chetan'. Siya had also visited Ketan's house after the funeral, when his sister Sanjana reportedly questioned her on the sequence of events. Her evasive answers and the fact that she wasn't 'grieving enough' also apparently raised suspicions in the family.

On the other side, Siya's father Pravin Goyal says he had no inkling of his daughter's relationship with Chetan. "Had I known, I would have taken action...but it did not come to my notice at all," he says. "If my daughter is guilty, then hang her...but at least give her a chance to defend herself. It is the court that must decide on her guilt." Defence lawyer Vipul Dushing, who is representing Siya, says, "There is no motive, the case is based on inferential prosecution...mostly the suspicions of the victim's parents." There were no witnesses to the crime, and mere suspicion cannot be a substitute for conclusive evidence, he points out.

The media coverage of the case has also put pressure on the police and the administration. Ketan's father Vishal met Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis on June 26, seeking a speedy trial. The state has now moved the trial to a fast-track court and appointed high-profile lawyer and BJP Rajya Sabha member Ujjwal Nikam as special public prosecutor. Meanwhile, the authorities are looking for evidence to build a watertight case. "There were 208 people at the fort at the time of the murder. We are hoping someone may have captured some incriminating photographic evidence," says a police official involved with the investigation. ■